

Prefix Sum + HashMap Templates

Core idea: subarray sum $[l, r] = \text{prefix}[r+1] - \text{prefix}[l]$.
To find a subarray with a target property, rephrase as: "has a prefix with value X been seen before?"
Store that X in a HashMap for O(1) lookup.

Core Template

```
// MENTAL MODEL: a subarray is the difference of two prefixes; remember prefixes seen so far and look up the complement.
// WHEN: "subarray sum equals/divisible by k", "longest subarray with sum X" – anything reducible to prefix[r]-prefix[l]
Map<Long, Integer> map = new HashMap<>();
map.put(0L, ???); // seed: empty prefix (sum=0) seen before index 0
long sum = 0;
// result = 0 (count) or Integer.MAX_VALUE (length sentinel) depending on problem

for (int i = 0; i < nums.length; i++) {
    sum += nums[i];
    long lookup = transform(sum); // what to look up (sum-k, sum%k, etc.)
    // use map.get(lookup) → update result
    map.put(storeKey(sum), storeValue(i)); // what to store (sum or sum%k → count or index)
}
```

What changes per problem:

Variable	Count problems (560, 974)	Length problems (325, 523)
Map value	count (how many times seen)	first index (earliest occurrence)
Seed value	map.put(0L, 1)	map.put(0L, -1)
On lookup hit	count += map.get(lookup)	maxLen = max(i - map.get(lookup))
Overwrite map?	Yes (merge count)	No (keep first index only)

Quick Reference Table

Read the two map-value modes first: **count** problems store prefix sum → how many times seen and answer "how many"; **length/index** problems store prefix sum → earliest index seen and answer "how long / where". The two modes also seed differently:

- Seed (0, 1) = the empty prefix has been **seen once** before we start — needed for *counting* (a prefix that itself equals the target counts as one valid subarray).
- Seed (0, -1) = the empty prefix lives at a **virtual index -1** — needed for *length* (length from start = $i - (-1) = i + 1$).

#	Name	Description	Intuition	Time	Space	Key Implementation
560	Subarray Sum Equals K	Count the number of subarrays whose sum equals k.	A subarray summing to k ends here for every earlier prefix equal to $\text{sum} - k$; count those prefixes.	$O(n)$	$O(n)$	Standard
325	Maximum Size Subarray Sum Equals k	Find the length of the longest subarray summing to k.	Same complement as #560, but store the earliest index so $i - p$ gives the longest subarray summing to k.	$O(n)$	$O(n)$	Standard
974	Subarray Sums Divisible by K	Count subarrays whose sum is divisible by k.	Two prefixes with the same remainder bracket a subarray divisible by k; count how many share each remainder.	$O(n)$	$O(\min(n, k))$	Standard
523	Continuous Subarray Sum	Return true if any subarray of length ≥ 2 has sum divisible by k.	Same-remainder pair means a divisible subarray; store the earliest index so the gap $i - p \geq 2$ proves length ≥ 2 .	$O(n)$	$O(\min(n, k))$	Standard
437	Path Sum III	Count the number of paths in a binary tree that sum to targetSum. Paths can start and end at any node but must go downward.	Apply the #560 prefix-count idea along each root-to-node path; undo the prefix on the way back up so branches stay independent.	$O(n)$	$O(h)$ (recursion + path-prefix map, $h = \text{tree height}$)	Standard
1	Two Sum	Given an array and a target, return the indices of the two numbers that add up to target.	Same "have I seen the complement before?" idea as prefix-sum, but the key is the raw value, so one pass finds the pair.	$O(n)$	$O(n)$	look up complement, not prefix sum

#560 Subarray Sum Equals K

Description: Count the number of subarrays whose sum equals k.

Map: {prefix_sum → count}. Seed (0, 1) — the empty prefix.

Lookup: how many earlier prefixes equal $\text{sum} - k$? Each one forms a valid subarray ending here.

Intuition: A subarray summing to k ends here for every earlier prefix equal to $\text{sum} - k$; count those prefixes.

```
class Solution {
    public int subarraySum(int[] nums, int k) {
        Map<Long, Integer> map = new HashMap<>();
        map.put(0L, 1);
        long sum = 0;
        int count = 0;
        for (int num : nums) {
            sum += num;
            count += map.getOrDefault(sum - k, 0);
            map.merge(sum, 1, Integer::sum);
        }
        return count;
    }
}
```

Time $O(n)$ | **Space** $O(n)$

#325 Maximum Size Subarray Sum Equals k

Description: Find the length of the longest subarray summing to k.

Map: {prefix_sum → first index}. Seed (0, -1) — empty prefix at virtual index -1.

Lookup: if $\text{sum} - k$ was seen at index p, length = $i - p$. Only keep first occurrence (maximizes length).

Intuition: Same complement as #560, but store the earliest index so $i - p$ gives the longest subarray summing to k.

```
class Solution {
    public int maxSubArrayLen(int[] nums, int k) {
        Map<Long, Integer> map = new HashMap<>();
        map.put(0L, -1);
        long sum = 0;
        int maxLen = 0;
        for (int i = 0; i < nums.length; i++) {
            sum += nums[i];
            if (map.containsKey(sum - k))
                maxLen = Math.max(maxLen, i - map.get(sum - k));
            if (!map.containsKey(sum)) // only store first occurrence
                map.put(sum, i);
        }
        return maxLen;
    }
}
```

Time $O(n)$ | **Space** $O(n)$

#974 Subarray Sums Divisible by K

Description: Count subarrays whose sum is divisible by k.

Map: {prefix_sum % k → count}. Two subarrays share the same remainder → their difference is divisible by k.

Lookup: how many earlier prefixes have the same remainder?

Watch out: Java % can return negative — normalize with $((\text{sum} \% k) + k) \% k$.

Intuition: Two prefixes with the same remainder bracket a subarray divisible by k; count how many share each remainder.

```

class Solution {
    public int subarraysDivByK(int[] nums, int k) {
        Map<Integer, Integer> map = new HashMap<>();
        map.put(0, 1);
        int sum = 0, count = 0;
        for (int num : nums) {
            sum = ((sum + num) % k + k) % k;    // normalize negative remainders
            count += map.getOrDefault(sum, 0);
            map.merge(sum, 1, Integer::sum);
        }
        return count;
    }
}

```

Time $O(n)$ | **Space** $O(\min(n, k))$

#523 Continuous Subarray Sum

Description: Return true if any subarray of length ≥ 2 has sum divisible by k .

Map: $\{\text{prefix_sum} \% k \rightarrow \text{first index}\}$. Seed $(0, -1)$.

Lookup: same remainder seen before $\rightarrow$ their difference is divisible by k . Check gap ≥ 2 .

Key difference from #974: store first index (not count), check gap, return on first hit.

Intuition: Same-remainder pair means a divisible subarray; store the earliest index so the gap $i - p \geq 2$ proves length ≥ 2 .

```

class Solution {
    public boolean checkSubarraySum(int[] nums, int k) {
        Map<Integer, Integer> map = new HashMap<>();
        map.put(0, -1);
        int sum = 0;
        for (int i = 0; i < nums.length; i++) {
            sum = ((sum + nums[i]) % k + k) % k;    // normalize negative remainders (matches #974)
            if (map.containsKey(sum)) {
                if (i - map.get(sum) >= 2) return true;
            } else {
                map.put(sum, i);    // only store first occurrence
            }
        }
        return false;
    }
}

```

Time $O(n)$ | **Space** $O(\min(n, k))$

#437 Path Sum III

Description: Count the number of paths in a binary tree that sum to `targetSum`. Paths can start and end at any node but must go downward.

Map: $\{\text{prefix_sum} \rightarrow \text{count}\}$ along the current root-to-node path. Seed $(0, 1)$.

Key difference: tree DFS — must **backtrack** (decrement count) when leaving a node, so sibling subtrees don't share state.

Intuition: Apply the #560 prefix-count idea along each root-to-node path; undo the prefix on the way back up so branches stay independent.

```

class Solution {
    public int pathSum(TreeNode root, int targetSum) {
        Map<Long, Integer> map = new HashMap<>();
        map.put(0L, 1);
        return dfs(root, 0L, targetSum, map);
    }

    private int dfs(TreeNode node, long sum, int target, Map<Long, Integer> map) {
        if (node == null) return 0;
        sum += node.val;
        int count = map.getOrDefault(sum - target, 0);
        map.merge(sum, 1, Integer::sum);
        count += dfs(node.left, sum, target, map);
        count += dfs(node.right, sum, target, map);
        map.merge(sum, -1, Integer::sum);    // backtrack - undo before returning
        return count;
    }
}

```

Time $O(n)$ | **Space** $O(h)$ (recursion + path-prefix map, h = tree height)

523 vs 974 — Side by Side

Both use `prefix sum % k` as the map key. The difference is one line:

	974 (count all)	523 (any length ≥ 2)
Map value:	count	first index
Seed:	<code>map.put(0, 1)</code>	<code>map.put(0, -1)</code>
On hit:	<code>count += map.get(sum)</code>	<code>if (i - map.get(sum) >= 2) return true</code>
Store:	<code>map.merge(sum, 1, +)</code>	<code>map.putIfAbsent(sum, i)</code>

560 vs 325 — Side by Side

Both use `prefix sum` as the map key, look up `sum - k`. The difference is one line:

	560 (count all)	325 (longest)
Map value:	count	first index
Seed:	<code>map.put(0L, 1)</code>	<code>map.put(0L, -1)</code>
On hit:	<code>count += map.get(...)</code>	<code>maxLen = max(i - map.get(...))</code>
Store:	<code>map.merge(sum, 1, +)</code>	<code>map.putIfAbsent(sum, i)</code>

When to Use `long` vs `int`

- Use `long` for the prefix sum when values can be large (e.g., `nums[i]` up to $10^4 \times n$ up to $2 \times 10^4 \rightarrow$ sum up to 2×10^8 , safe as int, but $10^5 \times 10^5 = 10^{10}$ overflows).
- Use `int` for the remainder key (modulo result is always in `[0, k-1]`).

Why `0L` (not `0`) in the seed

When the map is `Map<Long, Integer>`, the seed **key** must be a `long` literal:

```

Map<Long, Integer> map = new HashMap<>();
map.put(0L, 1);    // ✓ long literal → boxes to Long (matches key type)
map.put(0, 1);    // ✗ compile error: int boxes to Integer, not Long

```

- The `L` suffix makes it a `long` literal so it autoboxes to `Long`, matching the key type (the keys are `long` because `sum` is `long` for the overflow guard above).
- Subtle trap:** even numerically equal boxes of different types never compare equal — `Long.valueOf(0).equals(Integer.valueOf(0))` is `false`. Keeping every key `long` / `Long` avoids silent lookup misses.
- If `int` sums can't overflow, use `Map<Integer, Integer>` with plain `map.put(0, 1)` instead — simpler, no `L` needed.

#1 Two Sum

Description: Given an array and a `target` , return the indices of the two numbers that add up to `target` .

Intuition: Same "have I seen the complement before?" idea as prefix-sum, but the key is the raw value, so one pass finds the pair.

Algorithm: HashMap complement lookup. As you scan, for each `nums[i]` check whether its complement `target - nums[i]` was already seen. This is the same "has a value been seen before?" idea as prefix-sum problems, but the key is the raw value (not a running sum).

```
class Solution {
    public int[] twoSum(int[] nums, int target) {
        Map<Integer, Integer> map = new HashMap<>(); // value → index
        for (int i = 0; i < nums.length; i++) {
            int complement = target - nums[i];        // ← VARIATION: look up complement, not prefix sum
            if (map.containsKey(complement))
                return new int[]{map.get(complement), i};
            map.put(nums[i], i);                      // store value → index after the check
        }
        return new int[]{-1, -1};
    }
}
```

Time $O(n)$ | **Space** $O(n)$

- Always normalize Java modulo: `((sum % k) + k) % k` to handle negative inputs.